

Western Digital AV 160 GB WD1600AVBB

Tailored for the AV specialist

The AV series drives have been tailored to deliver optimised AV performance, and is targeted at the CE segment (HDD Recorders, Video Surveillance Recorders, etc.) and digital video professionals.

According to WD, a lot of research has gone into engineering these drives to incorporate enhanced features. These drives are touted to be very reliable with an MTBF (mean time between failures) of 1 million hours, and are rugged enough to survive high-temperature, always-on environments.

SilkStream technology provides continuous smooth playback of up to 12 HD streams with an assumed transfer block size of 2 MB per stream. Its compatibility with the ATA streaming

command set also enables CE customers to use standard stream management and error recovery options.

IntelliSeek is another technology incorporated here; it calculates optimum seek speeds to lower power consumption and vibration. Indeed, we found this to be a silent performer. The recording heads are parked off the disk surface during spin-up and spin-down and when the drive is off, to reduce wear and improve reliability and non-operational shock tolerance (350 G as opposed to 250 G

for standard drives).

The drive features Pre-emptive Wear Leveling, which means the drive arm frequently and evenly sweeps across the disk to reduce uneven wear on the disk surface—a common thing with AV streaming applications.

The drive consumes less power than non-AV drives; in fact, WD has removed the 3.3 V SATA power from this product. It also runs cooler than most.

The drive was better than most other non-AV drives in the synthetic benchmarks. In the real-world tests, it was fast in the sequential file copy test, but lagged behind all the drives we have tested thus



far in the assorted file copy test, taking at least 50% more time.

The 2 MB buffer appears to be too little in an age where 8 MB is the starting point (and it did hurt the performance). At the same price as a 320 GB drive, this fails to justify its price.

Specifications

160 GB; 7200 rpm; 2 MB buffer; SATA II

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Web site: www.westerndigital.com

Price: Rs 3,500

RATINGS	
Performance	★★★★☆
Features	★★★★☆
Value for Money	★★★★☆
Overall	★★★★☆

Sony Ericsson P1i

Filling the gaps

The P1i is the latest in Sony Ericsson's business line, succeeding both the P990i and the M600i—bringing the functionality of the former to the form factor of the latter. Its dimensions are nearly the same as those of the M600i, and its style statement is in Chinese—the shiny plastic sides and the chrome details look downright tacky. It's based on the same Symbian UIQ 3 platform as the P990i and M600i, with a few minor changes. The OS is definitely quicker, which is probably due to the oodles of program memory that the phone comes with—128 MB. Other than that,



there's nothing remarkably new here.

Just like the M600i, this one doesn't feature any soft-keys, and you operate it using either the stylus or your fingers on the touchscreen. There's also the three-way jog dial, which, thankfully, does away with the annoying protrusion featured on the previous phones. The screen itself is wonderfully vibrant and

quite responsive to the touch, but is, naturally, a fingerprint magnet. We recommend slapping on a screen guard the second you open the box—the screen's responsiveness will suffer a tad, but it'll be worth it.

The stylus is longer and easier to write with, and its locking mechanism seems much firmer than the M600i's flimsy setup. The QWERTY keypad is the same as that on the M600i—two letters to the key. Not too different from the M600i, but the keys do feel more tactile.

The 3.2MP camera is respectable, though not exceptional—indoor photos are a bit grainy, but overall, the clarity and colour balance of the photos satisfies. There's a second camera on the front for video calls, but you can't take self-portraits with it. Like the P990i, this model comes with a business card scanner. The feature works just as nicely (or as badly, depending on the card) as the one on the P990i.

The P1i supports 3G (but no EDGE) and Wi-Fi 802.11b. Wi-Fi speeds are decent, and battery life, thankfully, doesn't suffer for it.

The P1i isn't really light years ahead of the P990i, but it definitely nudges it off top spot. There's no annoying flip top, the QWERTY keypad can actually be worked with, the audio levels are louder, and the huge program memory has you multitasking like you've never multitasked before.

Specifications

Quad-band GSM; UMTS; Wi-Fi (802.11b); Symbian v9.1 UIQ 3.0; TFT touchscreen (256 K colours); 160 MB shared internal memory; Memory Stick Micro (M2) support (1 GB included); 3.2 megapixel camera; VGA video-call camera; FM radio

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Web site: www.sonyericsson.com

Price: Rs 24,000

RATINGS	
Performance	★★★★☆
Features	★★★★☆
Build Quality	★★★★☆
Value for Money	★★★★☆
Overall	★★★★☆